

## Checklist

# Engineering Executive: Working with Your CEO, Peers, and Engineering

## 1. Diagnose Your Support Level

**Assess whether you are:**

- ☐ **Supported** – Peers proactively help make your initiatives succeed.
- ☐ **Tolerated** – Others comply but don't actively improve or support your work.
- ☐ **Resented** – Your work is seen as a distraction or nuisance.

**If not clearly supported:**

- ☐ Identify which functions feel indifferent or resistant.
- ☐ Schedule 1:1s to understand their concerns.
- ☐ Clarify shared goals and success metrics.

## 2. Navigate Implicit Power Dynamics

**Avoid over-anchoring to the CEO's narrative.**

Gather perspectives from:

- CEO
- Board
- Executive peers
- Your own team

**Before acting:**

- ☐ Confirm whether Engineering is the problem or reacting to a broader issue.
- ☐ Distinguish symptoms from root causes.
- ☐ Validate assumptions directly with your team.

### 3. Bridge Conflicting Narratives

**When facing cross-functional tension:**

- ☐ List each function's perspective.
- ☐ Identify where perspectives overlap.
- ☐ Create a unified explanation that integrates concerns.
- ☐ Frame solutions as company-first, not function-first.

### 4. Avoid Anchoring to Past Experience

**Do not assume:**

- ☐ Your previous company's playbook will work here.
- ☐ Decision rights are the same.
- ☐ Resource levels are comparable.

**Instead:**

- ☐ Observe how decisions are made.
- ☐ Ask why processes exist.
- ☐ Adapt before implementing change.

### 5. Build an Alignment Habit

**Regularly invite feedback:**

- ☐ After exec meetings, ask: “What could I have done better?”
- ☐ Ask narrow, specific questions.
- ☐ Thank people for feedback.
- ☐ Demonstrate visible improvement.

**Ensure feedback loops exist:**

- ☐ Ask peers periodically.
- ☐ Ask direct reports periodically.

## 6. Focus on a Small Number of Changes

**Before launching new initiatives:**

- ☐ Review outcomes of prior changes.
- ☐ Confirm existing changes are working.
- ☐ Limit concurrent major initiatives.
- ☐ Deliver visible, meaningful wins.

**Avoid:**

- ☐ Starting multiple migrations at once.
- ☐ Rewriting processes without proving value.

## 7. Embrace Healthy Conflict (Resolve Unhealthy Conflict)

**Accept:**

- ☐ Conflict signals growth and complexity.
- ☐ Disagreement ≠ dysfunction.

**Watch for:**

- ☐ Recurring unresolved debates.

- ☐ Repeated re-litigation of decisions.

### **When conflict persists:**

- ☐ Clarify each viewpoint.
- ☐ Attempt synthesis.
- ☐ Establish structured escalation if needed.
- ☐ Reflect: “Am I preventing resolution?”

## **8. Use Structured Escalation**

If disagreement cannot be resolved:

- ☐ Step 1: Agree to resolve within 5 days.
- ☐ Step 2: Prioritize time to align directly.
- ☐ Step 3: If still stuck, perform a joint escalation with shared context.
- ☐ Step 4: Commit to the decision made by the escalated authority.

## **9. Survive Peer Panic**

### **If a peer begins blaming your function:**

- ☐ Assume stress before malice.
- ☐ Seek empathy and understand their pressure.
- ☐ Solve the problem together if possible.

### **If behavior becomes disruptive:**

- ☐ Focus on improving execution vs. replacing them (if feasible).
- ☐ Shield your team from unnecessary chaos.
- ☐ Encourage the CEO to clarify leadership decisions when needed.

## **10. Maintain a Long-Term Perspective**

**When uncertain, ask:**

- ☐ “What maximizes company impact over the next 3 years?”
- ☐ “Will this build or erode executive trust?”
- ☐ “Am I operating as a company-first leader?”